I wish I'd asked about her husband, King George VI, who died young. Or her brother-in-law, King Edward VIII, whom she'd apparently loathed. He gave up his crown for love. Gan-Gan believed in love, but nothing transcended the Crown. She also reportedly despised the woman he'd chosen.

I wish I'd asked about her distant ancestors in Glamis, home to Macbeth.

She'd seen so much, knew so much, there was so much to be learned from her, but I just wasn't mature enough, despite the growth spurt, or brave enough, despite the gin.

I did, however, make her laugh. Normally that was Pa's job; he had a knack for finding Gan-Gan's funny bone. He loved her as much as he loved anybody in the world, perhaps more. I recall him glancing over several times and looking pleased that I was getting such good giggles out of his favorite person.

At one point I told Gan-Gan about Ali G, the character played by Sacha Baron Cohen. I taught her to say *Booyakasha*, showing her how to flick her fingers the way Sacha did. She couldn't grasp it, she had no idea what I was talking about, but she had such fun trying to flick and say the word. With every repetition of that word, *Booyakasha*, she'd shriek, which would make everyone else smile. It tickled me, thrilled me. It made me feel…a part of things.

This was my family, in which I, for one night at least, had a distinctive role.

And that role, for once, wasn't the Naughty One.

30.

WEEKS LATER, BACK at Eton, I was walking past two blue doors, almost exactly the same blue as one of Gan-Gan's kilts. She'd have liked these doors, I thought.

They were the doors to the TV room, one of my sanctuaries.

Almost every day, straight after lunch, my mates and I would head to the TV room and watch a bit of *Neighbours*, or maybe *Home and Away*, before going off to sports. But this day in September 2001 the room was packed and *Neighbours* wasn't on.

The news was on.

And the news was a nightmare.